

Q You have just taken over from Anuj Kumar. Can you share a bit about your background?

I have been in the industry for about 20 years. I started off at Wipro in the early 1990s. I joined Red Hat through an acquisition in 2001. I joined as general manager, Red Hat India, in September 2012.

Q What is your strategy for the Indian market and what changes do you aim to bring about?

I am returning to India after five years, since my previous assignment was at Singapore. Red Hat India is an important constituency for us. Regarding where Red Hat is heading, I think we have a global strategy with a local execution and flavour. Our local strategy is very simple. We believe that the move to the open hybrid cloud is not a question of 'if' but a question of 'when'. A number of different forces come into play if we look at things from that perspective. I think it is important to understand that the cloud starts with commodity architecture. I think most of the enterprises in India are still not there but are stuck on proprietary and legacy UNIX infrastructure. So, for these organisations to move to the cloud, I think they have to make that initial step. It has already happened in most of the countries. India is lagging behind in this space, which is an opportunity for us. It has been the bread and butter for Red Hat's business, globally.

I think from a strategy perspective, we will follow our global strategy. We want to help our customers in their journey to the open hybrid cloud and actually deliver that for them. I see similarities in the cloud space and what we have done in the past ten years. If you go back to the roots of what the cloud promises, it's essentially four basic blocks, which are: 1. Everything on the cloud is built on commodity architecture, which gives customers choice and value as against a proprietary cloud. 2. Everything in the cloud has to be interoperable. 3. It's about value-based equations as nobody is buying licences any more on the cloud. The consumption is more demand-based, which requires, at the minimum, a subscription model, where the subscription period could be as low as a minute and as high as a year, and so on. 4. The last part is the scale. To do things that you want to do on the cloud, your technologies have to be extremely scalable and have to innovate at a faster rate. So if you consider these four essentials of the cloud, we have been offering them from Day 1. Ninety per cent of our business runs on commodity architecture. By the sheer definition of open source, it's all about open standards and interoperability. We have had a subscription model from Day 1. Because of the way the community does development, the architecture is highly modular and has built-in scale. So nothing lends itself better to the cloud than what we have been doing for so long. So, in that sense, it is just the execution of our strategy. We have built a solutions

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portfolio that goes beyond limits. In the late 90s, people used to associate networking with Cisco and Linux with Red Hat. We are growing beyond that with initiatives in the middleware market. We have acquired a lot of credibility on the virtualisation and cloud fronts. From that perspective, we are growing beyond Linux and offering end-to-end solutions to our customers.

Q Anuj Kumar was executing a similar kind of strategy. How do you plan to do it differently?

I think for us to succeed in India, we need a triangulation of parties, including the customers and our partners, SIs and ISVs, who are engaged in opportunities with Red Hat. I have been working very closely with Anuj for the last 24 months because I was managing the alliances portfolio for APJ. We actually set that strategy ball rolling. So, in a lot of ways, there is no major change in the strategy; it is just executing the strategy we have had in place for 24 months, jointly. At the end of the day, what we will try to ensure is that the messaging is consistent on all fronts—whether we deliver it, or it goes across from our partners who help us execute the strategy. The government and the BFSI will remain our major focus segments. I think my job here is to ensure that our customers and partners understand our strategies and the value that we bring to the market place. My job is to articulate the strategy and to reach out to them in multiple ways. And thus, we can reach a much wider audience than just customers and partners.

Q Initially, Red Hat was synonymous with Linux and now the company is gradually being known as an 'open source' brand. What kind of branding and positioning are you looking for Red Hat in your tenure?

I think it's an evolving phenomenon. We want to be a catalyst for communities of developers, customers and partners worldwide to help build software that is fundamentally being developed and conceived very differently from what you have seen before. So, in that sense, we play a very interesting role now. Think about the open virtualisation alliance. This alliance was created fundamentally to make sure innovation in technology around KVM and virtualisation was backed and driven by the industry heavy-weights. If you look at our role in